

Nookix Book Summary

The Handmaid's Tale Summary

by Margaret Atwood

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Book Overview: A Dystopian Warning Through One Woman's Story

The women slept on army cots in an old gymnasium, rows of them spaced apart so they couldn't talk. Guards called Aunts prowled the aisles with electric cattle prods slung from leather belts. Even they couldn't be trusted with guns. Outside, armed men from the Angels—the regime's elite soldiers—stood watch.

This was the Red Centre, where women were broken down and rebuilt as Handmaids. The women had a fantasy, Offred remembers. They thought that if they could just talk to the guards, maybe something could be exchanged. Some deal made. They still had their bodies. That was their fantasy.

But the guards weren't allowed inside. The women weren't allowed out except for twice-daily walks around an old football field ringed with chain-link fence topped with barbed wire. So they did what they could. They reached out and touched each other's hands across the space between cots. They learned to lip-read, lying on their backs watching each other's mouths, exchanging names from bed to bed.

This is where *The Handmaid's Tale* begins—not with a political manifesto or a historical explanation, but with the intimate, suffocating reality of one woman's captivity. The novel, published in 1985 by Margaret Atwood, has become one of the most celebrated and urgent dystopian works ever written. Its power lies not in grand spectacle but in the slow, methodical way it shows how freedom can be erased.

The Republic of Gilead is what used to be the United States. A theocracy overthrew the government by shooting the President and machine-gunning Congress, blaming it on Islamic fanatics at the time. Then came the roadblocks, the Identipasses, the censorship. Women lost their jobs. Their bank accounts were frozen, money transferred to husbands or fathers. Property was seized. The Pornomarts were shut down, presented as a moral victory while the real crackdown had only begun.

Offred is our narrator, a Handmaid assigned to the Commander and his Wife, Serena Joy. In Gilead, fertility rates have plummeted, and the regime's solution is simple: fertile women are forced to bear children for the elite couples who can't conceive. The Handmaids wear red—"the colour of blood, which defines us," Offred says. White wings frame their faces, obscuring vision and identity. Their names come from their Commanders. "Offred" means "of Fred." She belongs to him.

The novel moves between two timelines. In the present, Offred navigates the rigid rules of her existence: the shopping trips with another Handmaid named Ofglen, the monthly Ceremony where she lies in Serena Joy's lap while the Commander has perfunctory intercourse with her, the constant fear of being reported by anyone who might be an Eye—the regime's secret police. In flashbacks, she remembers her life before: her husband Luke, her daughter, her friend Moira, her mother's feminist activism. She remembers how they lived "by ignoring," how nothing changed instantaneously but crept forward like water gradually heating until you'd be boiled to death before you knew it.

Atwood builds her world through these contrasts. The past had problems—violent pornography, sexual assault, inequality. But the "protection" Gilead offers is a cage. The regime presents itself as saving women from a sinful, dangerous society, using carefully selected Bible passages to justify every cruelty. The Handmaids are told theirs is a position of honor. They are respected. They are valued. But they are also tortured with frayed steel cables for trying to escape, hanged for disobedience, sent to the Colonies to die slowly from toxic waste if they're deemed Unwomen.

At its core, this is a novel about control—of women's bodies, of language, of memory, of hope. The Aunts, women who enforce the system on other women, show how oppression recruits its own enforcers. The Commander, who secretly invites Offred to his study to play Scrabble, shows how even small privileges can create complicity. Moira, the rebellious friend who escapes the Red Centre, shows both the possibility of resistance and the crushing reality of what survival costs.

But what makes *The Handmaid's Tale* endure is not its political message alone. It's the voice of Offred herself—ordinary, conflicted, sometimes passive, sometimes sharp. She wishes her story showed her in a better light, "more active, less hesitant, less distracted by trivia." But she also knows that telling her story is itself an act of survival. "By telling you anything at all I'm at least believing in you," she says. "I believe you into existence."

The novel ends with an ambiguity that has haunted readers for decades. Offred steps into a black van, unsure whether Nick—the Commander's driver who became her lover—is truly helping her escape or handing her over to the Eyes. The last lines offer no resolution: "I have given myself over into the hands of strangers, because it can't be helped." Then comes an epilogue set in 2195, where academics discuss Gilead as a historical footnote. The regime fell. But Offred's fate remains unknown.

So we're left with a question that lingers long after the final page: In a world where freedom can be taken piece by piece, where comfort and survival can make us complicit, what would it take for any of us to truly resist?

The Red Centre: Indoctrination and the Co-opting of Religion

The Red Centre sat in what used to be a school gymnasium. Army cots lined the floor in rows with spaces between them so the women couldn't talk. Aunts patrolled with electric cattle prods slung from their belts. Outside, armed Angels stood guard. The Handmaids-in-training thought that if they could just speak to those guards, maybe something could be exchanged. They still had their bodies. That was their fantasy.

But the fantasy was a lie the regime cultivated. The Red Centre wasn't a prison—it was a conversion camp. And the conversion was spiritual as much as it was physical.

The Aunts were women who had chosen the regime over resistance. Aunt Lydia, Aunt Helena, Aunt Elizabeth—they carried cattle prods and Bibles in equal measure. They didn't just enforce compliance; they manufactured belief. Their method was simple: take the worst of the past, exaggerate it, and present Gilead as salvation.

"You see what things used to be like?" Aunt Lydia would say, showing old pornographic films where women were tied up, beaten, raped. "Consider the alternatives."

The message was clear: you were victims before. Now you're protected. Now you're honored.

But the real work of the Red Centre happened in the Testifying sessions.

Janine was a young woman, fragile and desperate to please. During one session, she stood before the assembled Handmaids and told her story. At fourteen, she had been gang-raped. She had an abortion. She was still a child when it happened.

Aunt Helena held up one plump finger.

"But whose fault was it?"

The other Handmaids chanted in unison: "Her fault, her fault, her fault."

"Who led them on?"

"She did. She did. She did."

When Janine began to cry, the chant shifted: "Crybaby. Crybaby. Crybaby."

Offred remembers this moment with shame. "We meant it," she says, "which is the bad part." They weren't pretending. They believed Janine was responsible. The indoctrination had worked.

This was the regime's most insidious tool: turning women against themselves and each other. If you could make a woman blame herself for her own rape, you could make her accept anything. The Aunts understood this perfectly. They taught the Handmaids that their bodies were the source of sin, that men were weak creatures easily tempted, and that it was women's job to set boundaries.

"God made them that way," Aunt Lydia would say. "It's up to you to set the boundaries."

The boundaries, of course, were always shifting. In Gilead, women had no boundaries at all.

Language itself became a weapon of control. The guards were called "Angels." The commanders were "Commanders of the Faithful." The women forced to bear children were "Handmaids"—a title taken directly from the Bible story of Rachel and Leah, where a barren wife tells her husband to impregnate her maid.

"Give me children, or else I die," the Commander reads during the Ceremony. "Behold my maid Bilah. She

shall bear upon my knees, that I may also have children by her."

The regime cherry-picked scripture to justify every cruelty. Wives were entitled to strike Handmaids because "there's Scriptural precedent." Homosexuality became "Gender Treachery." Deformed babies were "Unbabies." Women who didn't conform were "Unwomen."

Each word served a purpose. Each euphemism made violence easier to commit.

The regime also presented itself as protecting women from a past that was allegedly worse. Aunt Lydia would remind them of the dangers of the old world—the dating scene, the "meat market," the absent fathers and abusive husbands. She'd ask them to consider how much worse things used to be.

"This way they're protected," the Commander would later echo. "They can fulfill their biological destinies in peace."

But the protection was a cage. The peace was silence.

Janine's story didn't end with the Testifying. She became Ofwarren, assigned to a Commander's household. When she finally gave birth, the Handmaids gathered around her, chanting encouragement. The Wife sat on a birthing stool behind and above Janine, so that Janine was framed by her. When the baby came, it was passed immediately to the Wife, who lay in bed while the Handmaids stood between Janine and the bed so she wouldn't have to see.

Janine cried helplessly, burnt-out miserable tears. She would be allowed to nurse the baby for a few months. After that, she'd be transferred to see if she could do it again.

The Red Centre had trained her to accept this. It had trained all of them.

Offred remembers the sessions with a clarity that still stings. She remembers how the other Handmaids turned on Janine, how they meant every word. She remembers Aunt Helena's approving beam when they chanted in unison. She remembers the feeling of being part of something terrible and not knowing how to stop.

But she also remembers Moira, who refused to break.

Moira was the one who talked about giving "an underwhore party" like Tupperware, only with underwear. She was the one who faked sick to escape the Centre, who threatened an Aunt with a toilet lever, who got tortured with frayed steel cables for her trouble and still didn't give in.

"Nevertheless," Offred says, "Moira was our fantasy."

The fantasy of resistance. The fantasy of a self that couldn't be broken.

But even Moira would eventually be broken. The regime had a way of grinding down even the strongest

spirits. It just took time.

The Red Centre was where that grinding began. It was where the regime taught women to hate themselves, to fear freedom, to see their oppressors as protectors. It was where the co-opting of religion met the manipulation of memory, where scripture was twisted into shackles, where the word "fault" became a weapon.

And it worked. That was the worst part.

It worked on Janine, who blamed herself for her own rape. It worked on the other Handmaids, who chanted "Her fault" and meant it. It worked on Offred, who would later find herself thinking that maybe the regime was right, that maybe she deserved this, that maybe the expectations of others had become her own.

The Red Centre didn't just break women. It rebuilt them in Gilead's image.

Life as a Handmaid: Uniforms, Rules, and the Ceremony

From the indoctrination of the Red Centre, Offred was sent to her posting. She arrived at the Commander's house five weeks before the story begins, and from that moment, her world shrank to a set of rooms, a schedule, and a uniform that marked her as property.

The uniform was unmistakable. Red, from head to toe. "The colour of blood, which defines us," Offred says. The dress was shapeless, covering everything. But the most striking part was the white wings, the bonnet that framed her face. They were designed to obscure vision, to keep her from seeing clearly, but also to keep her from being seen. "We are for breeding purposes," she explains. "We aren't concubines, geisha girls, courtesans. We are two-legged wombs, that's all."

Her name was not her own. She was Offred, meaning "of Fred," belonging to the Commander whose first name was Fred. All Handmaids took their names this way. Ofglen. Ofwarren. The names erased their past identities, their families, their histories. They were defined only by the man they served.

The Commander's house was a large, old building with a garden that belonged to his Wife, Serena Joy. Offred's room was on the second floor. It was sparse: a bed, a chair, a window that wouldn't open fully, with shatterproof glass. They had removed anything you could tie a rope to. "It isn't running away they're afraid of," Offred thinks. "It's those other escapes, the ones you can open in yourself, given a cutting edge."

Her days followed a strict routine. Shopping with Ofglen, the other Handmaid assigned to the same household. Walks that were monitored. Meals brought by the Marthas, the domestic servants who disapproved of her. And once a month, the Ceremony.

The Ceremony was the central ritual of a Handmaid's existence. It took place in Serena Joy's bedroom, in the

large four-poster bed. Offred would lie on her back, fully clothed except for the white cotton underdrawers. Serena Joy would arrange herself above her, her thighs on either side of Offred, Offred's head resting on her stomach. Serena Joy would hold Offred's hands, which was supposed to signify that they were one flesh, one being.

Then the Commander would enter.

He would read from the Bible first, the old stories. "Be fruitful, and multiply." The Rachel and Leah story, where Rachel tells her husband Jacob to have sex with her maid Bilah. "Give me children, or else I die. Behold my maid Bilah. She shall bear upon my knees, that I may also have children by her."

Serena Joy would cry during the reading, trying not to make a noise. Offred would lie still, waiting.

Then the Ceremony itself. The Commander would lift Offred's skirt, just to her waist, no higher. He would enter her. But Offred had learned to separate herself from what was happening. "What he is fucking is the lower part of my body," she says. "I do not say making love, because this is not what he's doing. Copulating too would be inaccurate, because it would imply two people, and only one is involved."

Kissing was forbidden. That was the rule. No kissing, no intimacy, no pleasure. The act was impersonal, mechanical, designed only for procreation. "This has nothing to do with sexual desire," Offred explains. "This is a serious business. The Commander, too, is doing his duty."

The Commander would finish quickly. He would withdraw, rezip his pants, and leave the room without a word. Serena Joy would tell Offred, "Get up and get out," her voice filled with loathing. Offred would stand, and she would feel the Commander's semen running down her leg. That was the proof that the act had been completed, that she had been used for her purpose.

Afterward, Offred would return to her room. She would take the pat of butter she had saved from her meal, wrapped in a napkin and hidden in the toe of her shoe. She would rub it over her face and hands, because there was no hand lotion or face cream for Handmaids. That was a decree from the Wives, who didn't want them to look attractive.

The Ceremony was a monthly reminder of her objectification. She was not a person to the Commander or Serena Joy. She was a vessel, a means to an end. The child she might conceive would belong to them, not to her. She would nurse it for a few months, then be transferred to another posting to try again.

But Offred had found a way to cope. She dissociated. She separated her mind from her body. "I avoid looking down at my body," she admits, "not so much because it's shameful or immodest but because I don't want to see it. I don't want to look at something that determines me so completely."

She thought of her body as an instrument, once used for pleasure, now used for reproduction. "Now the flesh arranges itself differently," she says. "I'm a cloud congealed around a central object, the shape of a pear,

which is hard and more real than I am."

The Ceremony was the ultimate expression of Gilead's control. It was not just about reproduction. It was about power. The power to use a woman's body without her consent, to strip her of dignity, to reduce her to a function. And it was done with religious blessing, with biblical justification, with the full weight of the state behind it.

But there were small acts of rebellion. The butter on her face. The stolen daffodil she planned to press under her mattress for the next Handmaid. The Latin words scratched into the floor of her closet: "Nolite te bastardes carborundorum." Don't let the bastards grind you down. She didn't know what they meant at first, but she knew they were a message from someone who had been there before her, someone who had tried to leave a mark.

And then there was Nick. The Commander's driver, who lived above the garage. He was too casual, not servile enough. He winked at her once, and she wondered if he was an Eye, a spy for the regime. But when she crept downstairs after the Ceremony, still feeling the Commander's semen on her leg, Nick was there. He pulled her against him, his mouth on hers. It was the first time she had been touched with desire in months. "It's so good," she thinks, "to be touched by someone, to be felt so greedily, to feel so greedy."

But that was a secret. A small rebellion. The Ceremony was the reality. The uniform, the rules, the monthly violation. That was her life as a Handmaid. And she had learned to survive it by becoming two people: the body that endured and the mind that watched from a distance, waiting for the moment when it could feel something again.

Before Gilead: The Gradual Erosion of Freedom

Offred remembers the park. She was a child, holding her mother's hand. But they weren't there to feed the ducks. Her mother had brought her to a feminist protest. Women were burning pornographic magazines in a wire cage. Offred watched as "big flakes of paper came loose, sailed into the air, still on fire, parts of women's bodies, turning to black ash in the air." Her mother was among the women cheering, their faces lit by the flames. Offred didn't understand it then. She just remembered the heat on her face and the strange thrill of seeing something burn.

That memory sat uneasily beside her later life. Her mother was a feminist activist, the kind of woman who marched and shouted and refused to be polite. She once told Offred she was "prudish" and "conservative," frustrated that her daughter didn't share her fire. Offred's mother had fought for abortion rights, for equal pay, for the freedom her daughter would one day take for granted. And Offred had rolled her eyes, embarrassed by her mother's passion, uncomfortable with the anger.

Now she understood. But it was too late.

The rise of Gilead didn't happen overnight. It was a slow creep, a series of small steps that seemed reasonable at the time. Offred remembers the news reports first: the President shot, Congress machine-gunned. They blamed it on Islamic fanatics. Then came the curfews, the roadblocks, the Identipasses. The Pornomarts were shut down, and people nodded approvingly. Nobody wanted pornography anyway, they said. It was degrading to women.

Then her boss called her into his office. "I have to let you go," he said. "It's the law. I have to." Her bank account was frozen. All her money was transferred to Luke. She tried to use her credit card, and it was declined. "Any account with an F on it instead of an M," Moira told her, explaining the new law. Women could no longer own property. They could no longer work. They could no longer be independent.

Luke tried to comfort her. "It's only a job," he said. "You know I'll always take care of you."

Offred remembers thinking, "already he's starting to patronize me." Then she thought, "already you're starting to get paranoid." She dismissed her own instinct. He meant well. He loved her. He would provide.

But she noticed something else. Luke didn't seem upset by the new arrangements. He didn't seem worried. If anything, he seemed relieved. "He doesn't mind this," she realized. "Maybe he even likes it. We are not each other's, any more. Instead, I am his."

She pushed the thought away. It was easier to ignore.

There were marches, at first. Women filled the streets, demanding their rights back. But "the police, or the army, or whoever they were, would open fire almost as soon as any of the marches even started." Bodies fell. The marches stopped. Offred didn't go to any of them. "Luke said it would be futile and I had to think about them, my family, him and her." So she stayed home. She started doing more housework, more baking. She tried not to cry at mealtimes.

This is how it happens, she understands now. Not with a bang, but with a thousand small surrenders. "We lived, as usual, by ignoring," she says. "Ignoring isn't the same as ignorance, you have to work at it." And they worked hard. They looked away from the roadblocks, the frozen accounts, the women being dragged into black vans. They told themselves it was temporary. They told themselves it wouldn't get worse.

"Nothing changes instantaneously," she reflects. "In a gradually heating bathtub you'd be boiled to death before you knew it."

The memory of her mother burning those magazines haunts her now. Her mother had been right to be angry. She had seen what was coming. She had tried to warn her. And Offred had dismissed her as a radical, as someone who was making a fuss over nothing. Now her mother was gone—to the Colonies, Moira said, sweeping up deadly toxins, dying slowly. And Offred was a Handmaid, reduced to a "two-legged womb," her

body no longer her own.

She remembers Aunt Lydia showing them old pornography at the Red Centre. "Consider the alternatives," Aunt Lydia said. "You see what things used to be like?" The message was clear: Gilead had saved them from a world of violence and degradation. But Offred knew the truth. Gilead hadn't saved women. It had simply replaced one form of control with another. The pornography burning had become a metaphor for the regime itself—the destruction of images, the censorship of thought, the reduction of women to symbols.

Her mother had burned magazines to protest objectification. Now the state burned people for the same reason.

Offred thinks about Luke's face when he said, "I'll always take care of you." He meant it. He genuinely believed he was being kind. But his kindness was part of the problem. He didn't see that his protection was a cage. He didn't see that his love was a leash. He enjoyed being needed. He enjoyed being in charge. And she let him, because it was easier than fighting.

"We lived by ignoring," she says again. And the cost of that ignorance was everything.

The frog in the gradually heating water doesn't jump out because it doesn't notice the change. By the time it realizes it's boiling, it's too late. Offred and Luke were that frog. They watched the temperature rise—the job loss, the frozen accounts, the curfews, the disappearances—and they told themselves it was fine. They told themselves it would pass. They told themselves they were safe.

They were wrong.

The memory of her mother's protest flickers in Offred's mind like the flames themselves. "Parts of women's bodies, turning to black ash in the air." That image was supposed to be a warning. Her mother was trying to tell her that women were being reduced to body parts, to objects, to things to be used. But Offred didn't listen. She thought her mother was being dramatic. She thought the fight was over.

Now she knows the fight never ends. It just changes shape. And the greatest danger isn't the enemy at the gates—it's the comfort of the familiar, the ease of looking away, the seduction of being taken care of. Because once you give up your freedom for comfort, you don't get it back.

Moira's Rebellion and the Illusion of Escape

Offred carried Moira with her like a flame. In the darkness of the Red Centre, in the cold rituals of the Commander's house, in the long empty afternoons of her room—Moira was the proof that resistance was possible. She was the friend who had refused to break. She was the fantasy that kept Offred from drowning.

But fantasies have a way of dying when they meet reality.

The first time Offred saw Moira at the Red Centre, she felt safer. Moira arrived with a bruise on her cheek, three weeks after Offred had been taken. She was still herself—the same irreverent energy, the same refusal to be cowed. They arranged to talk through a hole in the bathroom stall wall, and Offred felt "ridiculously happy." Moira was her anchor. Moira was the one who wouldn't give in.

And she didn't. Not at first.

Moira faked sick to get out of the Centre. The Aunts discovered her plan. They tortured her with frayed steel cables, the kind used for industrial work, the ends unravelled into sharp wire. Moira couldn't walk for a week. Aunt Lydia stood over her and said, "For our purposes, your feet and hands are not essential." The message was clear: a Handmaid's body belonged to the state. Only the womb mattered.

But Moira tried again. She asked to go to the toilet. Inside the stall, she removed the long thin lever from the cistern—the metal rod that controlled the flush. When Aunt Elizabeth came to check on her, Moira pressed the pointed end against the Aunt's throat. She took the Aunt's clothes, her cattle prod, her whistle. And she walked out.

The other Handmaids heard about it in whispers. They were frightened—frightened of what Moira had done, frightened of what would happen to her, frightened of the hope that flickered in their own chests. "Nevertheless," Offred says, "Moira was our fantasy."

She was the escape hatch in Offred's mind. As long as Moira was out there, somewhere, free, then the system wasn't absolute. There was a crack. There was a way through.

Then the Commander took Offred to Jezebel's.

The hotel had been converted into a secret brothel for high-ranking officials. Women dressed in costumes—cheerleaders, bathing suits, bunny outfits—moved through the rooms like ghosts from a forgotten world. The Commander told Offred to put on makeup and a skimpy sequined dress. He thought he was giving her a treat.

Offred saw Moira before Moira saw her. She was wearing a black outfit with rabbit ears and net stockings. For a moment, Offred didn't recognize her. This couldn't be Moira. Moira was the one who got out. Moira was the one who fought.

But it was. Moira spotted her, gave the old signal, and they met in the bathroom.

The conversation was brutal in its honesty. Moira explained how she'd been caught again after her escape. She'd been given a choice: the Colonies, where she'd die slowly cleaning toxic waste, or Jezebel's, where she'd live a few more years as a prostitute for Commanders. She chose Jezebel's. She chose survival.

"You should figure out some way of getting in here," Moira told her. "You'd have three or four good years

before your snatch wears out and they send you to the boneyard. The food's not bad and there's drink and drugs, if you want it, and we only work nights."

Offred couldn't believe what she was hearing. This was Moira. This was the woman who had threatened an Aunt with a toilet lever. This was the woman who had been tortured and still tried again. And now she was telling Offred to join her. To give up. To make the best of being used.

"You don't mean it," Offred said. But she knew Moira did.

Offred thought: "I don't want her to be like me. Give in, go along, save her skin." But that was exactly what Moira had done. The system had broken her. Not with torture—though it had tried that too. It had broken her with a choice. A terrible, reasonable choice. Live a little longer in comfort, or die in agony. And Moira had chosen to live.

Moira also brought news of Offred's mother. She'd seen her in a film about the Colonies—a documentary shot by the regime to discourage resistance. Offred's mother was sweeping toxic waste, her body already failing. "She might as well be dead," Moira said. "You should wish it for her."

Offred tried to hold onto the image of her mother's cockiness, her refusal to be defeated. But she knew it wasn't true. The regime didn't care about cockiness. It crushed people with patience. It wore them down until they chose the smaller cage.

The Commander took Offred to a private room upstairs. He wanted to have sex with her there, away from the Ceremony, away from Serena Joy. He thought she might "enjoy it for a change." Offred told herself he wasn't a monster. She told herself to fake it. "Move your flesh around, breathe audibly. It's the least you can do."

And in that moment, she understood the full shape of her own capitulation. She was doing what Moira had done. She was making the best of it. She was choosing the smaller cage.

Moira's rebellion had been real. It had been brave. It had been everything Offred wished she could be. But it had also failed. The regime didn't need to kill Moira. It just needed to give her an option that felt like a choice. Jezebel's was a prison with better food. It was a cage with makeup and drugs. It was death delayed, not life lived.

Offred had done the same thing with the Commander. She had accepted his gifts—the magazine, the hand lotion, the Scrabble games—as though they were kindnesses. She had let herself be entertained by her own abuser. She had told herself that she was surviving, when really she was just learning to love her chains.

Moira had been the proof that resistance was possible. But Moira's surrender was the proof that resistance was pointless. Or rather, that resistance was possible only for a time. The regime was patient. It could wait. It could offer you a deal, and if you didn't take it, it would offer you another one, and another one, until you understood that the only real choice was between dying quickly or dying slowly.

Offred left Jezebel's with the taste of that knowledge in her mouth. Her fantasy was dead. Moira was not a symbol of hope. She was a warning. She was what happened to people who fought and lost. She was what happened to people who fought and won a little, and then ran out of fight.

The flame had gone out. And Offred was left in the dark, with nothing but her own small compromises and the knowledge that she, too, was learning to love her cage.

The Commander's Secret: Power, Patronage, and Small Favors

The Commander's study was an oasis of the forbidden. Books lined the walls, their spines a silent rebellion against everything Gilead stood for. Offred had been summoned there, against all protocol, and she entered with the strange sensation of stepping into another world. The Commander smiled at her, not with the predatory look she expected, but with something closer to embarrassment. He asked her to play Scrabble.

For Offred, the request felt like an offer of drugs. Reading and writing were illegal for women. The alphabet was a weapon, and the Commander was handing it to her. They played two games. She won the first, then let him win the second. She knew the rules of this new game too. Afterward, he thanked her, then asked for a kiss. She thought about stabbing him, about the blood coming out of him, hot as soup, sexual, over her hands. But that came later, in the retelling. In the moment, she didn't think about anything of the kind. She kissed him. He said, "Not like that. As if you meant it." And she did, or she tried to. He was so sad.

This was the beginning of a secret arrangement. Two or three nights a week, Offred would visit the Commander's study. Nick would signal by wearing his cap at an angle, and she would slip through the darkened house to a room that felt like another country. The Commander gave her gifts: a women's magazine, which she wanted with a force that made her fingers ache; hand lotion, which he offered as if indulging a child's wish for bubble gum. He let her read his books while he sat and watched, positively daddyish in his satisfaction. Her body grew lax, cosy even, in his presence. She was entertained. She was comfortable. She was being groomed.

The Commander wanted to explain himself. He wanted to justify Gilead. Sitting in his study, with the weight of his power between them, he told her that the main problem had been with men. Sex was too easy, he said. There was nothing to work for, nothing to fight for. The old world had been a meat market, a place where women were objectified and abused. Gilead had fixed that. "Better never means better for everyone," he said. "It always means worse, for some." He claimed that women were now protected, that they could fulfill their biological destinies in peace. When Offred asked what they had overlooked, she said, "Love." He dismissed this. Arranged marriages had always worked out just as well, if not better.

The hypocrisy was staggering. Here was a man who had imprisoned her, who forced her to endure the Ceremony each month, who held the power to send her to the Colonies or worse. And yet he sat in his

leather chair, drinking whiskey, trying to convince her that he was a benefactor. He didn't see the contradiction. He couldn't. For him, Offred was no longer merely a usable body. She had become something more: a pet, a confidante, a woman who might kiss him as if she meant it. He had deluded himself into believing that their relationship was mutual, that the power imbalance didn't matter.

But Offred was deluding herself too. She knew what she was doing. She was trading small pieces of herself for small comforts. The Scrabble games, the magazine, the hand lotion—these were bribes, and she was accepting them. She had become complicit in her own abuse. The previous Handmaid had done the same thing. She had visited the Commander's study. She had played his games. And when Serena found out, she had hanged herself. The Commander told Offred this thoughtfully, not sadly, as if explaining why the light fixture had been removed from her room. "If your dog dies, get another," was the unspoken message. And he had.

Yet Offred continued. She went back to his study, again and again. She kissed him goodnight. She let him take her to Jezebel's, where he dressed her in a garish outfit and paraded her through a secret brothel as if she were a trophy. He took her to a private room and initiated sex, deluding himself that she might enjoy it for a change. She lay there, moving her flesh around, breathing audibly, faking it. She told herself he was not a monster. She had to believe that, because otherwise how could she keep on living?

The psychological complexity of this relationship is the heart of section six. Offred is not a simple victim. She is a woman making choices within impossible circumstances, and those choices implicate her in her own oppression. The Commander offers her small privileges, and she accepts them. She tells herself she is surviving, but she is also being shaped by his attention. She becomes interested in him. She feels something that is not love but is not hatred either. She looks at him and sees a man, not a monster, and this makes everything more confusing.

The Scrabble game scene captures this perfectly. When the Commander asks for a kiss, Offred later imagines that she thought about stabbing him. She constructs a fantasy of resistance, a version of herself who would fight back. But the truth is that she didn't think about stabbing him at all. She just kissed him. She kissed him because it was easier. She kissed him because she wanted the hand lotion. She kissed him because she wanted to keep living. The fantasy of violence comes only in retrospect, when she is telling the story, when she can reshape the past into something more heroic. In the moment, she was just a woman trying to survive.

This is the insidious nature of power. It doesn't always work through force. Sometimes it works through small favors, through attention, through making the victim feel seen. The Commander gives Offred the illusion of choice, and she clings to it because the alternative is despair. She knows she is being manipulated, but she doesn't care. She wants the magazine. She wants the hand lotion. She wants to feel like a person, even if that person is a prisoner.

And so she sits in his study, her body lax, her mind drifting, while the man who rapes her once a month reads aloud from a book. She tells herself that she is doing what she has to do. She tells herself that she is not like the other Handmaids, that she has something special, that the Commander sees her as more than a body. But she knows this is a lie. She knows that the previous Handmaid thought the same thing, and she ended up hanging from a light fixture. She knows that the Commander's attention is not love, not kindness, not even respect. It is a form of control, softer than the Ceremony but just as effective.

The tragedy of Offred's situation is that she cannot afford to see this clearly. To see the Commander as he truly is—as her abuser, her jailer, her tormentor—would be to succumb to despair. So she accepts his gifts. She plays his games. She kisses him as if she means it. And she tells herself that this is survival, not collaboration. But the line between the two is thin, and she is walking it every night.

The Affair with Nick: Sexuality as Resistance and Distraction

Serena Joy is the one who suggests it. She comes to Offred one evening with a proposition. The Commander may be sterile, she says—a forbidden word in Gilead, where only women can be barren. If Offred wants to conceive, she should try with another man. She suggests Nick.

Offred agrees. What else can she do? The offer comes with a bribe: a picture of her daughter, the child she hasn't seen in years. So she waits in her room until midnight, when Serena comes to fetch her and sends her out to the garage, to the room above it where Nick lives.

She goes. And what happens there is not what she expected.

Offred first tells us a story about the encounter. A romantic story. In this version, Nick opens the door and there are no preliminaries. His mouth is on her, his hands are on her, and he's moving already, and she's alive in her skin again, arms around him. It's passionate. It's mutual. It's the opposite of the Ceremony.

Then she stops herself.

"I made that up," she says. "It didn't happen that way."

The real encounter is awkward. Nick offers her a cigarette. He looks at her unsmiling. She says she doesn't have much time, and he jokes: "Just squirt it in a bottle and you could pour it in." Possibly he feels used. They smile at each other, and then, without warning, Offred begins to cry. Nick puts his arms around her. He strokes her back. He comforts her. He kisses her and says, "No romance. Okay?" Meaning: don't risk yourself for me.

And then they have sex. Offred admits she's not sure how it happened, not exactly. She made up the sounds of thunder to cover up the sounds she was ashamed of making. But she knows she betrayed Luke

afterward—not through the act itself, but through her own response. She felt something.

This is the heart of Offred's affair with Nick. It is real. It is mutual. It is, in its small way, an act of rebellion. In a world that has reduced her to a two-legged womb, that has outlawed kissing and pleasure and any touch that isn't for reproduction, she is reclaiming her body. She is having sex for herself. She goes to Nick time after time, without Serena knowing, without any excuse. "I did not do it for him," she says, "but for myself entirely."

But the affair is also a distraction. And a dangerous one.

Ofglen, the Handmaid who has revealed herself as part of the resistance, asks Offred to spy on the Commander. To search his desk. To find out anything she can. But Offred refuses. She says she's too afraid. She scarcely bothers to sound regretful. The truth is simpler: she no longer cares. The Commander is no longer of interest to her. She has Nick now.

She admits it explicitly: "I no longer want to leave, escape, cross the border to freedom. I want to be here, with Nick, where I can get at him."

This is the terrible irony of the affair. Offred's relationship with Nick is the most genuine human connection she has in Gilead. It is the opposite of the Ceremony—passionate, consensual, alive. But it also makes her complacent. It gives her a reason to stay. It makes the life she endures—the monthly rape, the constant surveillance, the loss of her daughter—seem bearable. She no longer wants to escape because escape would mean losing him.

And so she stays. She continues to visit the Commander's study. She continues to play Scrabble and kiss him goodnight. She continues to lie in Serena Joy's lap during the Ceremony while the Commander fucks the lower part of her body. But she does it all with Nick in the back of her mind. He is her secret. Her pleasure. Her reason to keep going.

But he is also her reason to stop fighting.

This is the tension the novel explores through Offred's affair. Sexuality can be resistance. It can be an act of defiance against a regime that tries to control every aspect of desire. But it can also be a distraction. It can make you forget that you are still a prisoner. It can make you settle for small pleasures instead of demanding freedom.

Offred knows this. She knows she is choosing Nick over rebellion. She knows she is letting Ofglen down. She knows that the previous Handmaid, the one who scratched "Nolite te bastardes carborundorum" into the closet floor, also visited the Commander's study and ended up hanging from a light fixture. But she doesn't care. She wants to be with Nick. She wants to feel alive in her skin. She wants to close her eyes and pretend that the world outside his room doesn't exist.

And so she does. She goes to him. Time after time. For herself. Entirely.

Salvaging and Particicution: Violence as a Safety Valve

But the affair couldn't last forever. Reality had a way of breaking in. And when it did, it came in the form of blood.

The Handmaids were summoned to a district Salvaging. For women only. Offred walked with the others to a stage where three women sat—two Handmaids and a Wife. They would be hanged. Everyone knew the procedure. A long rope ran through the crowd like a fuse, each woman placing her hands on it in turn, then touching her heart. The gesture was meant to show unity with the executioners. Consent. Complicity in the death of another woman.

Offred did it. She placed her hands on the rope. She touched her heart. She watched the women die.

But the Salvaging was only the first act. After the bodies were cut down, the Handmaids were told to form a circle. A Particicution. A man was dragged into the center. His face was unrecognizable from the beating. He smelled of shit and vomit. Aunt Lydia announced that he had been convicted of rape. That a pregnant woman had lost her baby. The details were sparse, but the intent was clear.

The Handmaids surged forward.

Offred felt it too. The bloodlust. She wanted to tear, gouge, rend. She wanted to destroy. And for a moment, this felt like freedom. "We are permitted anything," she thought, "and this is freedom."

The man tried to speak. "I didn't—" But no one heard him. The crowd was already moving.

Ofglen shoved her way to the front. She pushed the man down, sideways. Then she kicked his head. One. Two. Three times. Viciously. Then the others reached him, and he disappeared under a mass of arms, fists, feet.

Offred was shocked. Outraged. Sickened. She confronted Ofglen afterward. Why had she done that? Why had she been so brutal?

Ofglen's answer changed everything.

The man wasn't a rapist. He was a political dissident. He was one of them. One of Mayday. Ofglen had knocked him unconscious to spare him the suffering of being torn apart while fully conscious. She had kicked him three times in the head out of mercy.

This was the regime's true genius. The Particicution wasn't just a punishment. It was a safety valve. The Handmaids lived with constant rage—rage at their imprisonment, rage at the Ceremony, rage at the loss of their children, their bodies, their lives. That rage had to go somewhere. If it were directed at the regime, it would become rebellion. So the regime gave them an outlet. A man accused of rape. A chance to kill. A

release.

And it worked. Offred felt the bloodlust. She wanted to tear him apart. She was a participant, not just a witness. The regime had made her complicit in murder.

The next day, Ofglen was gone. A new Handmaid appeared, also called Ofglen. The old one had hanged herself when she saw the black van coming for her. It was better that way. She died before they could torture her into betraying the others.

Offred felt relief. Great relief. She was safe. She was still alive. She promised God that she would give up everything—Nick, the resistance, any trace of rebellion—if only she could keep on living. "I resign my body freely," she thought, "to the uses of others."

But even that promise wouldn't save her. Serena Joy had found the costume from Jezebel's. The lipstick on the collar. The betrayal. She confronted Offred with cold fury. "You're just like the other one," she said. "A slut. You'll end up the same."

Offred went to her room. She was orderly and calm. She knew what was coming. The black van. The Eyes. The end.

But when the van arrived, Nick came to her room instead. "It's Mayday," he said. "Go with them."

She didn't know if she could trust him. He could be an Eye. The van could be a trap. But she had no choice. She went down the stairs, past the Commander's worried face and Serena's furious one. She stepped into the darkness of the van. Or else the light.

She didn't know which.

The novel ends there, with Offred's fate unknown. But the Historical Notes, set two hundred years later, reveal that Gilead fell. That the story was found on cassette tapes, recorded after her escape. That Nick was likely telling the truth. That she made it out.

But what happened after? Did she build a new life? Was she recaptured? Sent to the Colonies? Killed? The historians don't know. They can't know. They only have her voice, preserved on tape, telling her story to anyone who would listen.

And that, perhaps, is the only victory she achieved. She told her story. She believed her listener into existence. She refused to let Gilead erase her. Even if no one knows what happened to her, her voice remains. Her testimony survives.

In the end, that's all any of us can do. Tell the truth. Leave a record. Hope that someone, somewhere, will hear it.

The Ambiguous Ending and Historical Notes: Hope and Uncertainty

Offred went to her room. She was orderly and calm. She knew what was coming. The black van. The Eyes. The end. But when the van arrived, Nick came to her room instead. "It's Mayday," he said. "Go with them." She didn't know if she could trust him. He could be an Eye. The van could be a trap. But she had no choice. She went down the stairs, past the Commander's worried face and Serena's furious one. She stepped into the darkness of the van. Or else the light. She didn't know which.

"I have given myself over into the hands of strangers," she thought, "because it can't be helped."

That's where the novel's main narrative ends. Offred steps into the unknown, and the story stops. We never learn if Nick was telling the truth. We never learn if she reached freedom or was taken to her death. But the book doesn't end there. After Offred's final words, there's something else: the Historical Notes.

The Historical Notes are a transcript from an academic symposium, set two hundred years later, in 2195. A professor named Pieixoto stands at a podium and delivers a lecture about "The Handmaid's Tale"—which, it turns out, is the very story we've just heard. The document, he explains, was not a document at all. It was a series of approximately thirty cassette tapes, found in a metal footlocker in what used to be Bangor, Maine. The city was known to be a stop on the Underground Femaleroad, the network that helped Handmaids escape. The tapes had been recorded after Offred escaped from the Commander's house. She had survived that night. She had made it out.

But what happened after that? The historians don't know. They can't know. They tried to trace her, but they drew blanks. The names she used—Luke, Moira, Janine, Nick—were probably pseudonyms, adopted to protect the real people. The Commander was likely a man named Waterford, but even that is uncertain. "Serena Joy," the professor notes drily, appears to have been a "somewhat malicious invention" by the author. The only thing they know for certain is that Gilead fell. The regime that had seemed so powerful, so permanent, became just another subject of academic study. Commander Waterford met his end in one of the earliest purges, charged with having liberal tendencies and harboring a subversive.

The professor tells his audience that Offred's story is a valuable historical artifact. But he also says something troubling. He warns his colleagues against "passing moral judgement upon the Gileadeans." Their job, he says, is "not to censure but to understand." He even makes a joke about the title "The Handmaid's Tale"—a pun on "tail," as in the tale of a woman's body. The audience laughs. For them, Gilead is ancient history. The horror is distant. They can afford to be objective.

But we, the readers, cannot. We've just lived through Offred's story. We've felt her terror, her hope, her despair. We've seen the Ceremony, the Particution, the Salvagings. We've watched her give up on escape, then be saved anyway. We've heard her voice, preserved on tape, telling her story to anyone who would

listen. And now we're told that her ultimate fate is unknown. Did she "reach the outside world safely and build a new life for herself?" the professor asks. "Or was she discovered in her attic hiding place, arrested, sent to the Colonies or to Jezebel's, or even executed?" They have no way of knowing.

Offred's story ends with a question: "Is this my end or a new beginning?" It's a question that has no answer. She steps into the van, and we never see her again. We only know that she recorded her story afterward, that she survived that night. But what came next? Did she find her daughter? Did she reunite with Luke? Did she and Nick build a life together? Or did the regime catch up with her eventually? The tapes give no answers. They only give her voice.

And that voice, in the end, is the only victory she achieved. She told her story. She believed her listener into existence. She refused to let Gilead erase her. Even if no one knows what happened to her, her voice remains. Her testimony survives. The regime that tried to silence her, that tried to reduce her to a two-legged womb, that tried to make her disappear into history—that regime itself disappeared. But Offred's voice did not.

The Historical Notes offer a strange kind of hope. Gilead fell. Theocracy didn't last. The regime that seemed so absolute, so inescapable, became a footnote in academic journals. The professors who study it are glib and detached, making jokes about the Handmaids' suffering, but at least they're studying it. At least it's over. At least the world moved on.

But the Notes also offer a warning. The professor's detachment is itself disturbing. He treats Offred's story as an object of analysis, not as a testimony of suffering. He's more interested in identifying the Commander than in honoring the woman who survived. He makes jokes while discussing her trauma. The audience laughs. And you wonder: Is that what we do, too? Do we read Offred's story and treat it as entertainment? Do we analyze it from a safe distance, forgetting that for her, it was real?

Atwood gives us no easy answers. The ending is deliberately ambiguous. Offred's fate is unknown. Gilead fell, but we don't know how or why. The historians are studying the regime, but they seem to have learned nothing from it. The story ends not with a resolution, but with a question. And that question is directed at us.

What would we have done? Would we have resisted, like Moira? Would we have complied, like Offred? Would we have been among the Aunts, enforcing the regime's rules? Or among the Wives, benefiting from the oppression of others? Would we have looked away, as most people did? Would we have told ourselves that it wasn't our problem?

Offred's voice reaches across the centuries, preserved on those cassette tapes. She told her story because she believed someone would listen. And we did. We heard her. The question is: What will we do with what we've heard?

The novel ends with the professor's lecture, but the real ending is in our hands. Offred steps into the van, and

we don't know if she lived or died. But we know she spoke. We know she left a record. We know she refused to be silent. And that, perhaps, is the only victory any of us can achieve. Tell the truth. Leave a trace. Hope that someone, somewhere, will hear it.

And maybe, just maybe, they will.